Welcome to your next lesson: The power of the situation.

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've just learned, what's up next, and how you learn best.

Step by step, you're moving forward.

Imagine someone asked you: “Do you think you could ever act cruelly just because of the situation you were put in?” 😈➡️😟

Most people say “no way” — this lesson is about why that confidence can be wrong.

I’ve just pulled up a short video on the Stanford Prison Experiment for you. 🎥

Watch it first, then tell me in one sentence:

What was the most surprising or disturbing part of the experiment to you?

most surprising to me that the participants labeled inmates internalized it and put up with it for 15 bucks a day

Yeah, that part hits hard. 😐

They didn’t just pretend to be prisoners — they started to feel like real prisoners, even though it was a study, they were free to quit, and it was only $15 a day.

Let’s zoom in on one idea from what you noticed:

Social role = the set of behaviors, feelings, and expectations that come with a position (like “guard,” “prisoner,” “teacher,” “boss”).

In this study:

The “inmates” started thinking and acting like real prisoners (hopeless, obedient, emotionally broken).
The “guards” started acting like real abusive guards, even if they weren’t that way in normal life.

So instead of their personality (disposition) leading, the role and situation took over.

Quick check-in, super simple:

If you had to pick, which explains the prisoners’ suffering better in this experiment:

their inner personality, or
the powerful situation and role they were put in?

Just answer in your own words, and we’ll build on that next. 💭

the situation they were pi in, had it been jovial pretend guards being nice to them or breaking character a lot it would have been diffferent i think

Exactly — you’re thinking about this in a very “situational power” way, which is the goal here. 🎯

You’re saying:

If the guards had acted jovial and kind,
Or broken character a lot (“hey, remember this is just a study, you’re safe”),
then the prisoners probably wouldn’t have sunk so deep into that helpless, real-prisoner mindset.

That’s the core idea:

Change the situation and role behavior, and you change the moral outcomes.

Let’s connect this to something simple in real life 👇

Think about a referee in sports:

When they put on the uniform, hold the whistle, and step on the field, they act very strict and authoritative.
Off the field, that same person might be relaxed, kind, maybe even shy.

It’s the role + setting that pulls out that strict behavior.

Now I want to compare this to something you saw earlier: Milgram’s obedience study.

Very short reminder:

Milgram: People shocked a “learner” because an authority figure (scientist) told them to.
Zimbardo: People acted cruelly or helpless because of the role + environment (prison setting).

In your own words:

How would you say Milgram (obedience) is different from Zimbardo (prison roles)?

Don’t worry about being perfect — I just want your rough take.

well most obvious is milgram didnt tell the test subject he was a test subject he though the other guy was, in this they all knew from the start they were justt participants

Nice catch — you’re picking up a big difference already. 👌

Milgram:

The real subject thought: “I’m just helping an experimenter test someone else.”
He didn’t realize he was the one really being studied.
The pressure came mainly from a clear authority figure giving direct orders: “Please continue.”

Stanford Prison:

Everyone knew: “I’m a participant in a study.”
But once they were assigned roles (guard/prisoner), the prison-like situation started to feel real.
The pressure came less from direct orders and more from the role, the uniforms, the setting.

So:

Milgram = authority obedience (“a powerful person tells you what to do”).
Zimbardo = role + environment (“the situation and role pull you into behavior you never

planned”).
Want to try a quick multiple-choice check to lock in “situation vs. personality” using the prison experiment?

Let's do it

What do you think? Take your time and pick the best answer 👇

In the Stanford Prison Experiment, some guards became cruel and some prisoners became very passive and hopeless. Based on what you know, which explanation best fits this pattern?

A.

Many of them already had cruel or weak personalities before the study (dispositional explanation).

B.

The prison-like environment, uniforms, and assigned roles strongly pushed them into guard/prisoner behavior (situational explanation).

C.

They all secretly wanted to be actors, so they exaggerated their behavior for fun.

D.

It was random chance; the experiment setting didn’t really influence their actions.

A i would hope to think those with a rue acifist sympathetic set of values wouldnt fall so easily into it

I get that hope — most of us want to believe strong pacifist or caring values would protect people. 🌱

But what Zimbardo’s study (and Milgram too) keeps shouting at us is:

Even people with good values can act in bad ways when the situation + role are powerful enough and there are no strong safeguards.

So when we explain the guards’ cruelty, psychologists lean toward:

Situational explanation: uniforms, power, group norms, prison setting, lack of oversight. Not mainly “they were secretly bad people.”

You’re thinking in the right direction, though:

Your answer A is more dispositional (about inner traits).

B/C/D would be more situational (about the context and setup).

Want me to walk through why each option points to “personality” vs. “situation” really clearly, side by side?

Yes, please break them down

Love that you asked for this — let’s go step by step. 🌱

Remember:

Dispositional = about inner traits/personality (“they’re just cruel”).
Situational = about the context/role (“the prison setup pushed them”).
Here’s a clear breakdown of each option:

A. “They just had cruel personalities all along.”

Focus: who they are inside (their character).
This says: “They were already bad people; the study just revealed it.”
→ Dispositional explanation.
B. “Wearing uniforms and having power over others pushed them to act more harshly.”

Focus: uniforms + power + role of guard.
This says: “The situation of being a guard changed how they behaved.”
→ Situational explanation.
C. “The prison-like environment made both guards and prisoners start acting the part.”

Focus: environment + “acting the part” of the role.
This says: “The fake prison felt real enough to shape behavior.”
→ Situational explanation.
D. “Most people, put in the same guard role and setting, might act similarly.”

Focus: “most people in that same role/setting”.
This says: “It’s not just them; the situation could change many people.”
→ Situational explanation.

So:

Dispositional: A
Situational: B, C, D

In the Stanford Prison Experiment, psychologists mainly use B/C/D-style reasoning: the context and roles had huge power over moral behavior.

Quick check for you, Ron 🎯

If a psychologist says,

“Ordinary college students turned cruel mainly because of the prison role and environment, not because they were ‘born cruel.’”

Are they giving a situational or dispositional explanation?

Just answer with one word: “situational” or “dispositional.”

situational

What do you think fits best here? 👇

In the Stanford Prison Experiment, which explanation BEST fits why the guards’ moral behavior changed so much over a few days?

A.

They were naturally cruel people, and the study just revealed their true personalities.

B.

The guard role, uniforms, and prison-like setting gave them power and pushed them toward

harsher behavior.

C.

They were paid so much money that it overpowered their morals.

D.

They misunderstood the instructions and thought cruelty was required to get a good grade.

b

Nice, B fits with how you've been thinking about it. 🎯

Let's zoom out now and tie this directly to the mastery goal: how context shapes moral decisions in the Stanford Prison Experiment.

Very short step□by□step picture:

Normal students were randomly assigned to be guards or prisoners.
The context was built to feel like a real prison: uniforms, IDs, cells, rules, night counts.
Guards quickly started:
using harsh rules
humiliating prisoners
escalating punishments
Prisoners:
became passive, anxious, depressed
some cried or had breakdowns
many accepted the abuse instead of walking out, even for $15/day
The key takeaway:
The situation (prison setup + roles + power imbalance) pushed ordinary people into immoral behavior (guards) and painful submission (prisoners), more than their personal values or personalities did.

So when we explain what happened, we say:

Context (situation) shaped their moral decisions much more than inner "good" or "bad" character.

To finish strong, I'd like you to reflect on real life for a moment:

Can you think of one real-world environment (workplace, school, military, sports team, etc.) where a role might push someone to go against their own morals?

Just name the situation and how the role could pressure them.

After that, I'll help you design one safeguard that could keep people from sliding into that Stanford-Prison-type trap.

rerstarant cook could be told to work in unsanitary condions by manager or owner desooite their training and obligation to the public

That's a really strong example, Ron. 👌

Situation: restaurant kitchen

Role pressure:

Cook is expected to obey the manager/owner
There's pressure to be "a good employee" → don't argue, don't slow things down

Even though their training and values say: “Serve safe, clean food.”

So you could get:

Moral belief: “People deserve safe food.”
Moral decision under pressure: “I’ll ignore that dirty surface / expired food just this shift so I don’t get in trouble.”

That’s exactly the kind of thing Zimbardo was warning about:

A strong situational structure (hierarchy, time pressure, norms) can quietly override personal morals.

Let’s do the safeguard now 🔧

Take this same restaurant situation.

What’s one rule, system, or protection you’d put in place so cooks feel safe to refuse unsanitary orders?

For example: anonymous reporting, surprise inspections, “no-retaliation” policy, posted health code, etc.

You pick one and state it in your own words.

id say a stacxk of forms to be taken and sent in on your own anonymosly to the heath board or corporate

That’s a great safeguard. ✸

You’re basically designing a situational fix to support morals:

Problem situation: “My boss is pressuring me to serve unsafe food.”
Your safeguard: Anonymous forms the cook can send directly to the health board or corporate, without going through the boss.
Effect: The system now supports the cook’s values, instead of punishing them for doing the right thing.

So just like the Stanford Prison setup pushed people toward worse moral choices, your form system changes the setup to make better moral choices easier and safer. 🎯

You’ve actually hit the mastery goal here:

You explained how context (roles, power, environment) can push people to act against their values.
You used both the prison experiment and your restaurant example to show it.

If you feel done with this topic, I’d say you’re ready to move on to the next lesson.

Are you ready to wrap up this “power of the situation” lesson and continue to the next one?

Yes, I'm ready

Awesome work, Ron. 🎓

Here’s what you nailed in this lesson:

You used the Stanford Prison Experiment to show how roles + environment can push ordinary people into cruel or submissive behavior.

You clearly separated situational explanations (“the prison setup and power structure caused it”) from dispositional ones (“they were just bad people”).
You created a sharp real-world example (the restaurant cook) and even designed a situational safeguard (anonymous forms to the health board/corporate) to protect moral behavior.
That’s exactly the kind of thinking psychologists want: not “I’d never do that,” but “What kind of situation could make anyone do that, and how do we design it better?”

You’re all set on The power of the situation ☑
Whenever you’re ready, you can jump into the next lesson from your Learn tab, and I’ll be right there with you.